



FAZED

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Faze: (v.) disturb or disconcert (someone).

What fazes you?

We're all disturbed by something, whether that's outside or inside our heads.

Here at Epigraph Press, we believe in the power of art and writing to subvert, transform, and metamorphose. We aim to intersect the arts and culture and to publish the unconventional while celebrating minorities in any intersectional variation of the term. Founded in 2018.

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COW.
Casey Reinhardt

The shutters are banging against the house again. The clasp that holds them in place has come loose and the endless clatter will drive me mad if I don't fix it.

I shove my feet into the boots near the door and slip on a heavy winter coat. The front door creaks as it opens and I make a note to grease that in the morning, too. A wall of freezing air hits and I feel like I'm suddenly encased in ice. I shake it off and struggle toward the bushes which line the front of the house. They sway as winter winds send my hair fluttering in every direction. I pull my hood up so that I can see and step into the garden, reaching through bramble for the metal hook.

The wind is persistent, trying to pull me away and though I try my best to keep steady, it's difficult to keep footing on the wobbly bricks which line the garden's edge. I can feel the cool metal brush against my fingertips, but it slips away. The shutter bangs and bangs and bangs and I stand staring at it. If I concentrate hard enough, maybe I can fix it with my mind.

I will myself to reach out toward it, but find I am unable to move.

With a sudden whirl, as if pulled by the wind, I am turned to face a field across the road where a brilliant light shines. A loud smack behind makes me stumble forward. The shutter hammers against the siding in the rhythm of my heart. A maddening synchronicity. My breath forms clouds in the air which get carried away by the wind. I can't move, so I try to forget the cold.

I'm facing a field I don't remember seeing before, fighting against the force holding me in place as a brilliant metal ship slips down from the sky, light blinding. It burns something into my mind, something I recognize. A cow.

The idea of the ship and the cow cross in my mind. The images cycle through my brain. The ship looks three-dimensional and real, the cow does not. Each time the images flicker in and out, the ship gets fainter, the cow sharper. My mind rejects the idea of the cow like an infection, an invasive species. I pull against the force holding me in place, helpless.

The wind stops. The shutter gives one last hard rap against the house and the world shifts back to a serene winter night.

It takes a minute to realize I have control of my body again.

It was only a cow. I laugh to myself as I start looking for the metal hook, sparing a moment for one last glance over my shoulder toward the field, which is already fuzzy and out of focus.

It was only a cow.

I secure the shutter, lock the door and tip-toe back into bed where the sounds of my wife's snores keep me awake.

Every time I ask myself what I'd just seen, cow is returned.

Not 'cows mooing in a field.' Not 'cows wandering about' or 'cows escaping from a pen.' Just 'cow,' accompanied by a two-dimensional and cartoonish looking image.

I can remember very clearly that I'd walked outside at 3:40 in the morning, and returned at 4:22. I was outside for forty-two minutes.

Her snores jostle me awake every time I begin to drift off. I work to convince myself it was all just my dreaming mind.

I wake up feeling very much like I hadn't gotten enough sleep. My body lags; my limbs are heavy. I make coffee without putting any water in the pot and it leaves a burnt coffee scent that follows me wherever I go.

My wife takes over in the kitchen and sets a steaming mug in front of me while I sit at the kitchen table, looking out the window.

"Did you hear anything strange last night?" I ask.

"Nope," she says, with extra emphasis on the "p" as if she's already irritated by my unnecessary worries.

"The shutter slipped out of its clasp again. I had to run out in the middle of the night and fix it. There was also this... cow."

"Cow?" She looks at me through narrowed eyes.

"A Cow. But just, like, the side of it."

"Meera, we live in a city. There are no cows."

"But, there was a cow. I saw it."

"Maybe you just had a dream?" she says, sipping her coffee and opening a book.

"No. It wasn't a dream," I say. "Are there any farms around here?"

"Twenty miles off at least." She takes a bite of her toast and I realize there is a piece in front of me, too. I take a bite, but don't taste anything. All of my senses are preoccupied trying to sort the cow situation. It is lodged in my mind like a piece of food between two teeth. It feels out of place.

"It's weird, I just... I can't seem to let it go."

She huffs and sets her book down. "Let what go?" she asks.

"The fucking cow."

"Are you going to be ok?" She sets the back of her hand against my forehead like I'm five years old she's checking for fever.

"No." I finish off the coffee while looking out the front window at the houses lining the city street and eat my toast.

Apiary Musk
Julian/Sara Mithra

Vanilla pods sun their long legs in brittle disregard for harvest, browning and ripe. The slope of ugly perfume roses bloom indistinguishable shades of parchment. Ella depetals an entire basket with dry hands and a firm twist. Mason jars packed with salt suck the moisture but spare the delicate perfume.

Petals rustle through Ella's fingers like crepe or scabs or valentines. They tear too easily to string together into evanescent necklaces across the four poster for fertile dreams. Eager scent paws at her neck, searching out bees that might have staggered through an open transom. Florid aroma flirts through the anteroom and clings to art nouveau wallpaper bees, unable to tell the difference between embossed and living wings. The saturated conservatory and library sacrifice unfinished letters and embroidered pillows.

The gardener, Sage, moonlights as an apiarist, reckoning vanilla and orange blossom and jasmine webbing between branches. Three white hives come to life. The perfumed voice carries over distance. A voice so sweet with nectar that the bees forgo tea roses for the transom. They drunken against the doily (so like the ragged caterpillar-nibbled edge of an oversized petal).

Bees fill our ears with their questions, burrowing for the very center of a precious flower, which we've already tossed over the fence. They're hot for bud vitals, yellow fuzz, fritillary lobes, and crenellated sprouts. We've strewn aprons, skirts, petticoats, and bloomers belonging to the rose across the trestle table, but not her organs. Nor any deep place a proboscis can probe.

Housebound bee, sick with desire, settle for drilling knotholes in a brown moiré drawer. Remember that once your stinger mirrored a thorn and you could challenge a rose. You would duel back to back, lancing at each other's sharpness.

Escape
Erica Wahlgren

The walls were falling down around us, the ground splitting, our very foundations ripping at the seams. The floor pitched and rolled beneath our feet as we scrambled for the exit hatch. I ran and ran, crashing into people, into debris, searching for the way out. I burst through the hatch just as our world finally crumbled. Stark white walls, fluorescent lights, and a panel of unfamiliar faces in lab coats faced us.

Gallery Attendant
Winston Plowes

I sat in the chair
counted them in
like minded pairs
walked and shuffled
into another dimension
frames of red and brown colour
dead fingers pointing the way
A truth I could see

and counted them in
alone and in pairs
who squeezed hands as they walked
through the smoke
to be held in frames
spread from dead fingers
to a new truth
when I sat in the chair

The Hardy Boys and The Mystery of the Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder
Chris Bullard

Frank Hardy flipped on the electric light in his brother's bedroom and shook Joe awake. "What?" Joe muttered, "Was I screaming in my sleep again? I hope I didn't wake Aunt Gertrude." Ever since *The Secret of the Old Mine* when Joe had been trapped in a passageway filled with poisonous spiders, he had been having bad dreams.

"You're fine," Frank assured him, "just sweating a bit." Frank threw a towel onto the bed and while Joe mopped up the moisture on his sheets, Frank explained why he was visiting Joe in the middle of the night.

"I was in the parlor near dad's bar when I looked out the front window and saw someone waving a torch from the top of the abandoned lighthouse down at the Bayport rocks. I'll bet you it was one of those smugglers dad's been investigating. They're probably signaling their ship that's safe to come into the harbor."

"Wow," Joe exclaimed. "We've got 'em red-handed. Let's tell dad so he can notify the authorities."

"Have you forgotten?" Frank said to his younger brother, "Dad's still in Chicago tracking down the missing shipping invoices. Anyway, the authorities haven't been so glad to see us since we tipped that reporter to the fact that somebody seemed to have lost all the drugs that we found in *The Hidden Attic*."

"No," Frank continued in a firm tone, "you're just going to have to climb up to the top of the lighthouse to see who's there."

"Me? Why am I the one to do all the investigating?"

Frank turned away from his brother. "Gee, you know, Joe. I can't go up there. I mean, there's just too many stairs." It was true. After the wooden overlook in *The Pinnacle Hideaway* had collapsed and Joe had spent a night clinging to a single railing above a mountainous gorge, he had shied away from heights, to the point that he now slept in the basement of the Hardy family home.

"Well, I guess I can handle it," said the younger Hardy brother bravely. But as he started to put on his clothes, there was a peal of thunder causing Joe to throw himself onto the floor beside his bed.

"C'mon," Frank said to his brother, "it's just a little noise. It's nothing to worry about."

"Yeah, sure," Joe rejoined in a quivering voice, "It's nothing to you, but it sounded like dynamite going off to me. You didn't have to put up with everything blowing up around you like I did in *The Gunpowder Mill Hoax*. I still haven't gotten my hearing back."

"Well, I had to deal with Captain Rafferty and his pirate crew."

"So what, I bet you never had to climb a wall of knives."

Frank decided to placate his brother. "Look, just stay here. I can use those binoculars mom keeps for bird-watching to spot whoever is up on the lighthouse. If I go out to the point I can see the whole bay from there."

"I don't know about that, Frank," Joe told his older brother. "I heard that someone saw a bear out there last year. You'll have to be careful."

"A bea...bea...bear?" asked Frank as he slumped into a stuffed armchair beside his brother's bed. Since he had been chased across the ice by a ravenous polar bear in The Haunted Igloo, Frank couldn't even see Winnie the Pooh without feeling a need to throw up.

Frank looked at his own hands for a few minutes before saying, "You know, Venus is particularly bright this evening. I bet that's what I saw. Not some guy with a torch, just Venus shining right over the top of the lighthouse. It's really nothing at all."

Joe was about to say that he agreed with Frank, that it must have been some sort of optical illusion, when another clap of thunder rattled the house and he slid under the bed.

Frank sat for a few more minutes clenching and unclenching his fists. When he got up from the chair, he called out to Joe that he was going to get some scotch from their father's bar before he went back to the basement. His dad, the Detective Fenton Hardy, had started locking the liquor cabinet before he left the house but Frank knew where he kept the key. Frank had always been good at solving mysteries.

As he stood, Frank heard his brother ask him to get his pill containers from a nearby table. He pushed the medicine tray under the bed to Joe who asked if he needed any sleeping pills. "Go ahead," Joe told him, "I've got so many I sometimes don't even know how many I took."

"That's okay," Frank replied. "I've got my own stash downstairs."

"Good night, Frank," Joe murmured.

Frank wished his brother good night in reply, but Joe was already asleep. Frank could hear him moaning, "Spiders, no!"

Frank knocked back a couple of scotches before he gingerly made his way downstairs to the basement. After locking the door behind him and sliding a chair up against the handle he lowered himself onto a beat-up sofa and felt for the knife he kept under the pillow. It was there, so he was safe. He looked up at the ceiling and waited for morning.



Ode to Brockport
Catherine Keller

When people ask how it was going to a 'party school',
This is what I tell them,
About Brockport, out in the boonies of New York.
I tell them that it was the zenith of the town,
How everything revolved around the college,
Nothing but dozens of small towns for miles,
With the city of Rochester forty minutes away,
There's even a tiny town called Alabama in upstate New York.
It was a wasteland of glorified self-destruction,
Where coyotes and drunk college kids howled at the moon.
This was the first taste of freedom most of us have ever had,
So of course, we ran wild.
We streaked through the campus fountain,
After a night of drinking Svedka,
And we smoked out of an apple at the top of a waterfall,
That was ten minutes away from campus.
Pabst flowed like water,
And people were not to be trusted.
It's full of people who think Buddhist tapestries and psychedelics,
Make you enlightened,
The booze and bud are cheaper than my hometown,
Friendships are fleeting if you can't offer substances.
This is not American Pie.
We were self-sufficient and self-destructive.

Four Greek life institutions banned by the university,
For being categorized as organized gang activity,
6 were expelled and arrested my last semester,
For hazing pledges and animal torture.
We were blessed with the Erie Canal in our backyard,
And ten years before I got there,
The unrecognized frats would force pledges to swim across the canal,
Blindfolded, at night, while drunk,
They also forced them to sleep with at least one girl per week,
In order for them to men worthy of brotherhood,
And don't even get me started on the sexual injustices,
Of the D3 sports teams and gym rats.
While I have never known a woman
who hasn't been sexually assaulted in some way.
I myself have had beer bottles and various things,
Thrown at me while I'm walking home at night.
This is a place where the same girls who attend anti rape rallies,
Abandon the women they came to the party with,
On a mattress and helpless.
Where men behave likes boys and girls pretend to be women,

Reclaiming their femininity and masculinity
By cheating on their 'lovers',
Sometimes via sexual assault.

People talked shit about the city, the suburbs, and small towns,
How they're all scum and the number is increasing,
Of those who shoot up,
But this campus was toxic,
There were racial rivalries and
Too many hate crimes against minorities,
White people hurling slurs during a 'Black Lives Matter' protest,
Then the anonymous-posting Twitter-esque social media emerging,
And hatred did not have to hide behind a hood anymore,
It could be shared and sympathized with.
Not many people were safe,
A mixture of urban kids with suburban
And small-town Trump supporters,
And of course, performative liberals,
Almost as if people believed hate would make their hearts full.
There was some clash, some comradery,
But tension constantly lingered.

During orientation night, 7 months before my first semester,
A girl overdosed on molly on the second floor,
Of the dorm I was staying in overnight.
I have held a lot of hair back,
While others and myself hurled into toilets and bushes,
From too much liquor.
Then there was the riot that wasn't,
There were rumors that people were setting cars on fire,
When really what happened was;
The cops busted every party and eventually forced the bars to close,
So there's hundreds of drunk students running around Main St.
And there's cops from three counties,
Some people got tazed, punched, and arrested,
But the numbers were few and the charges were minor.

Six deaths in my first year,
Two from the bridge and four from the bottle,
And three of them were seniors, which is almost worse,
They were so close to getting out.
Five houses got robbed in one month,
Fentanyl and coke cut with horse tranquilizers,
Took the lives of at least twelve in two weeks in the county alone.
A friend had to have a colonoscopy,
Because he was shitting blood,
From drinking so much,
Freshmen year, I dormed in the same building,

Where a girl was beat to death by her boyfriend,
And my first semester, a guy on the second floor,
Was stabbed.

I've seen a girl overdose on the sidewalk
The week after my friend tried to kill himself,
I've helped a guy through heroin withdrawals,
And helped my roommate from self-harming
When her mom died.

Every year, the death toll rises.
This is what a 'party school' looks like.

Splintering
Julian/Sara Mithra

I'm eating like I got hired to it. Punch-in, fry an egg, spill chorizo, flip the tortilla with almost scorched fingertips. Boil over grits. Ignore warnings about chicken feet or pork belly; spit out gristle. My jaws work the assembly line, kneading dumplings, biscuits, cornbread. Stoke the bessemer red, nestle foil-wrapped potatoes wet with butter. Steal truck ice for cold bowls of blueberries and cream, honeyed yogurt, cherry pie, pumpkin pudding. On company errands, I'll scurry a pocket of pistachios. Food travels. Apples. Burritos. Scooping out an avocado with an oily thumb.

Ladies murmur and warm their hands at my middle, but they don't feel a kick. Instead, they table fussy food (artichokes, fish with translucent bones, pomegranate nibs, leg of crab) to pick at. They've arranged the gifts in a lopsided heart, the wrapping paper stamped with ducks and bows and happy fruit. They're suspicious of my rapid growth but love to flounce confetti games to train me in how to be more like them: pink, blue, safety first.

I hate to spoil their fun. She'll be brown as loam and sleep through the storm.

When the women warn of some hurt, I chalk it up to a jealous curse. Yet it descends—a splintery pain skidding across rough hewn wood. It adzes the floorboards, like I'm not giving up my secrets quick enough, until it punches through.

Unhampered light brings me to the acre I've birthed. Dry. Impeded by rocks. My hands grow rough with plowing and tilling to defy the drought that turns the sky a moribund gray. In lieu of rain, I water furrows with swollen milk. I find space for seeds to move in, but the soil is far from rich. The worms must persevere in acoustic secret. I forgot to summon the birds, the pits, the bees, the clippings. Nothing green takes root in a field of ankle-twisting cavities.

After all the hardscrabble, bare-knuckle clawing, my fingernails rip out and my lungs catch a damp. The seasons reverse: congested clouds drip ghostly water. Underneath, nothing to find but dirt and mud, mud and dirt. There's no treasure spilling sun in my lap. Just the wet ground and worms and chipped china lip and trench and jawbone of a raven piled beside the hole.

What else to do but build a fence? Mothers may chide, what terrible sprouts, what rotten vines. But I'll know the centipede twirls past a grub, and larvae spins in its raw skin. The boundary might hint at these invisible tunnels, channeling a route thick as an umbilical cord.

Shattered Glass
Erica Wahlgren

shattered glass

"I don't see any marks"

splintered wood

choked, suffocated

"You will have to testify if you want anything done"

one
wrong word

shock

"I know the statistics, I am good at my job"

adrenaline

shame

disappointment

"Most female victims of intimate partner violence were previously victimized by the same offender"

Victim

Victim

Victim

"I am allowed to lie to him and ask him to come back here"

asking

for it

devastated

"Its legal even if you are uncomfortable"

shaken

battered

"Do you want counseling"

damaged

"No? Oh, so I assume you took him back?"

Reminiscence
Catherine Keller

I have a horrendous memory
They say depression deteriorates the temporal lobe
But I distinctly remember
The salty taste of the flesh on my fingers
Coaxing the half-digested Doritos
Up my throat and into the trash.

I remember slicing my skin with silver
That promised a release so sweet
My mouth started watering
I remember thinking
This is what I deserve.
I remember the taste of my first cigarette
And that it wasn't to fit in or look cool
I figured I would be dead in a year anyways
So one wouldn't hurt.
I remember looking down at my chest
And wondering when my femininity would sprout
When the girls around me were blooming
I remember saying no to that guy at that party
Who clearly did not understand the meaning of the word.

I remember being slammed up against a locker
In the girls room after gym during middle school
And no one bothered to help me
I remember choking down that first pill
Thinking 'this is what I have to do now'.
I remember having all thirty-seven pills in my sweaty palm
Thinking that this should be enough
I remember waking up and being covered in red splotches
From where I tried to rip my skin off the night before
Thinking that would liberate me.

I remember all of the gin that I drank
To try to prevent me from remembering
I remember not caring, then caring too much
I remember being in my psychiatrist's office when she asked
"Have you had any thoughts of suicide or wanting to harm yourself?"
And the measly 'no' that slipped passed my lips
When I hacked myself two nights prior.

I remember thinking it had to get better, right?
Thankfully, I don't remember all of it
The nights that were hard to forget
And although I slip up on birthdays and names and appointments

I never forgot my serotonin solution
Because I never forgot that I wanted to recover.

Talking to My Mother About Suicide and #MeToo, 2018
SaraEve

She said a hundred times. She said a thousand times. — Dave Matthews Band

I'm not saying I'm sure I know what happened. What I know is this- if it happened to someone else and I didn't warn them, I don't know how I would sleep at night. I mean, until the medication, I didn't sleep. What I know is this- I'm not the only one who has been harassed/ violated/ manipulated/ gaslighted/ date raped/ assaulted, but I am the one people keep asking about. I mean, no one ever asked me, outright, what happened, how I became this Pandora's Box of secret violations, names redacted from the reports. Why my name is the only one they want in blood. What I know is this- when my mother asked me about the #MeToo movement, I told her I was one of them. I mean, I defended my right to stay silent for so long. Even to my own family, I defended myself. Even when I needed to untangle what was what and who stood where in the end, instead I defended my decision to stay silent. To keep the names and details to myself. What I know is this- sometimes, I dream about him and fear waking up with his name in my mouth. I mean, I have dreams where I am simply a rabbit caught in the wolf pen. The last thing I remember before waking up is the taste of blood. What I know is this- I know enough to stay away. I mean, I still don't feel like I am doing enough. He is still out there; no one is holding him accountable. They want our blood instead.

The Me Without Perception
Alicia Alcantara-Narrea

I am not offended. When I was younger my family ate pastries and syrup and drank the richest ice tea. And they gorged and they ripened and they flattened out. When I grew older I had wheat bread in one hand and 2% milk in the other. If I was lucky my cupboards held some form of grain or soup. I spent plenty of time in the bread aisle of the grocery store wondering how far I could stretch a dollar. My grocery list was short: bananas, bread, and pasta. Grain will always be cheaper. At times it's just easier to live on less. There's no point in eating. There are other things to do. Never mind any previous childhood notions. I still practiced double mastication or no mastication at all.

Take your finger and place it on your tongue. Now move it backwards, slowly, towards your throat. Move it further still until you feel it. Did you feel the sensation, that knee jerk reaction, to vomit everything up? If you didn't, try again. If all that came up was air or spit or acid, try again. You're going to get the hang of this. You may even secretly like it.

"I can go a little while longer"

Chew or don't chew. Swallow or don't swallow, but faint and faint again. Track everything going in and everything coming out. There are three thousand five-hundred calories in a pound. Count the seconds then the minutes then the hours while you mindlessly scour the grout. Too many trials. Too many perfections to meet. Too many, but not for you. This time you'll hold out even longer 'cause it doesn't have the power. You do. It's just food. It's a not a grumble or an ache or a hollow. It's forgettable. It can wait.

"Pain don't hurt the same"

Every time is different, every secret room, every ritual. Some experience euphoria and others embarrassment. You feel accomplishment. Like the first time you went to the dentist, and he said to brush your teeth to keep it white; and you spent the entire day in the bathroom brushing and brushing, wondering why your teeth weren't any whiter and the sink was just all red.

People may ask you how it feels to force your finger down your throat. Don't be embarrassed. You know more than they do. You know the ones that are doing it too, and hiding it better; living with their head held high. That growling inside tightens your spine, girdles your stomach, and suddenly you're the person you want to be.

"This life is all I know"

There's vomit everywhere and ribs jutting out. There are bones against tired flesh. There's no air

to breathe and spots in your eyes. There's no strength, no will; there's sweat. There's fear, 1

there's pride and the absence of fight. There's regret and shame and sorrow. There's tears and wails and curling into yourself and the moment you start the cycle again.

"I'm always ready for a war"

I wake and breathe. No. I wait to breathe and when I finally do I think about what I have to live for. I think about who may judge me. Me and the food that sits beside me. No, not beside me. It's hidden in the back corners of dirty drawers. It's flushed away in bowls and pipes and rivers. Who am I fighting? I'm so tired of fighting. But I need to keep fighting; for myself, against myself, for a reason to not stop breathing.

"It isn't in my blood"

Ask me again if I have an issue with food. I'll tell you how I survived it. I can tell you that I was scared that I couldn't breathe, that the darkness was a room too lonely. That in order to forgive me, I needed to admit fragility. That no one was going to pray for me, that all I had was me, that what it was wasn't ugly. I wasn't ugly. I am not ugly. I was. I just was. There's ever a was, but there will be a be. There's a chance and a hope and not endlessness. There's existence and another choice to make. There is and there's me. The me I used to see, the me without perception; the me in reality and the me of my truth.

Ode to the Other Women
SaraEve

Pulling my hair out of the drain, collecting the
broken teeth of haste, plastic smashed against
skull, hands plastered to neck. O, how you
survived a tornado and lived to tell, the house
of your love a foundation beat upon, gasping
and soaked. I never meant to be the stray cat
in the yard; it is a survival instinct, living
off scraps. O, how you remind me of my small
place. Bless your children. Bless your family.
Bless your pets. Bless your house. Bless
this mess. Bless the few hours he becomes,
a new feral, bless the scratches I welcome,
a reminder of catch and release.



The Caterpillar Curse
Edward Varga

Art Gamble did a dime in the state lockup for armed robbery, after which time he decided to go straight. Being on the outside was harder than he remembered, so he looked for a career whose atmosphere most resembled that of a penitentiary. He found his bliss pushing broom in an elementary school. Life as a janitor brought him joy most days. On one particular day, however, it brought back the fear.

It was early. The light was dim. Art thought he was alone. Two figures floated toward him in the murky light, a tall man, and a little girl.

"Excuse me sir," the man called out. "We're looking for Ms. Barrow's classroom. Can you help us find it?" Art did not answer the man. His eyes were fixed instead on the little girl. "Well?" the man prodded.

Art scuffed his nose with the back of his sleeve and said, "This's her room." Art opened the door for them.

Olivia Barrow stared at the handsome stranger in the doorway. Her cheeks felt slightly flush and warmer than the tea in the cup she held in both hands. "You must be Mr. Rooney," she cooed, flexing her neck muscles to tighten her skin. She placed the cup neatly on a coaster and stood with shoulders back.

"Please, call me Henry," he said, smiling back and raising one eyebrow slightly. "I must say, they didn't make teachers as pretty as you when I was a little boy." Henry and Olivia shared a cocktail party laugh which soon died out. "This is my daughter, Cynthia."

Olivia noticed the Janitor was still watching them. "Thank you for helping them find my room, Mr. Gamble. You should return to work now." Once the door closed, Olivia bent down before the girl. Henry stared at the small of her back and the patch of white skin exposed by her sweater creeping up. "You must be Cynthia. Does anyone call you Cindy?"

"Don't call me Cindy!"

Henry barked, "Be nice, Cynthia."

"It's alright, Mr. Rooney. First days are hard. Now, why don't I show you two around." She turned slowly. Henry's eyes watched. Cynthia noticed her father being a perv. "You'll spend your entire day with me and your classmates in this room. As you can see, I've meticulously organized each area to foster specific learning." Olivia stooped in front of the girl. Henry peered down the teacher's neckline. "Cynthia, do you know what meticulously means?"

She answered without losing her frown. "It means extremely organized and well thought out."

Olivia's hands clasped together and she stood quickly. "You are very bright for a second grader. Perhaps you'd be interested in exploring my grammar corner?"

"No," Cynthia growled. "I like life science."

Henry added, "That's for sure. She's extremely interested in entomology." He slid a hand in his pocket as if he were bragging about his golf game. "Ever since I divorced Cynthia's mom, she can't get enough of it. She spent a year with arachnids. Then she moved onto all sorts of bees. Now she's exploring the world of caterpillars. Right down the alphabet. I guess that makes both of you meticulous, eh?"

Olivia let out a gentle laugh and touched Henry on the arm. Cynthia glared. Olivia withdrew her hand and cleared her throat. "All that study of insects must be fascinating."

Henry nodded and became somber. "Fascinating, and yet unfortunate." There was a noise at the door. The three turned to look and through the glass saw Art quickly turn and walk away.

"May I ask why it's unfortunate?" Olivia said.

"Because of the accident with my second wife, Suzanne. I blame myself, really. Cynthia was so eager to study insects that I established an account with a specimen supply house so she could order whatever she wanted to indulge her interests. Admittedly, I was not happy when I found a variety of spiders in my coat pocket, but I never thought... it was a container of african bees. Cynthia must have left them in Suzanne's car. A most painful death."

"Mr. Rooney, I am so sorry for your loss." Olivia clutched her hands across her chest and batted her eyelids sympathetically.

"Oh, it's fine. We're over it all now. New town, new house, new school --"

"New insect," Cynthia added quickly.

Olivia pried her stare off of Henry's fabulous eyes and said, "What are you studying now?"

Cynthia said, "I just got a box of puss caterpillars. They're very hairy."

Olivia's mouth went dry. "Well, perhaps you'll bring one in sometime to share with the class."

"Maybe," Cynthia answered slowly.

Henry checked his watch. "I've a train to catch, so it's time for me to say goodbye." Cynthia reached out to embrace her father but was pushed aside as his hand met the teacher's. "I look forward to seeing you again, Olivia." Cynthia watched the pair rhythmically pump their hands. As they did, she drew a squirming mass of hair from her pocket and squeezed it between her fingers until she felt it pop. Henry and Olivia were still shaking hands when she dunked it into Ms. Barlow's meticulously prepared cup of tea and swirled it around.

Henry left the classroom with no recognition of his daughter, who slumped down in an empty desk. Ms. Barlow ceased attempting to make a connection with the girl and instead took a long and satisfying sip of her tea. Cynthia smiled, then looked at the window in the door. Art was staring back at her while leaning on his broom, which felt heavier than it did before. He remembered how in prison you could never take your eyes off of the ones that were in for murder. Even if no one told you what they did, there was just something about them that made it hard to look away.

Zephyr and the Smith
Julian/Sara Mithra

The sizzle of the horseshoe hitting the surface of the water still had the power to unhinge Shay, though her skill with tongs meant she never dropped the newly forged piece into the bucket. Her father taught her three foundational rules of the smith: don't stoop, don't rush, and don't make a cut you can't heal. Gripping the horseshoe with a horse's strength, Shay looked to the opposite wall where hung her father's last piece, a hook for a bridle. For the second time that morning, she wondered what he would have said about the child.

Clinking the horseshoe into an uneven pile on the workbench, Shay stepped into the well-tamped square in front of the smith. For one thing, the child would not reveal her location with giggles or prattle. Never did she converse with flowers or corn husk dolls or the mouser. And yet she wasn't melancholy or contrary. When she first arrived, Shay considered herself lucky to take in such a foundling who carried wood and scraped plates without complaint.

Master Lucian thought the child delightful, although Friar Jasper crossed her double, just to be sure. Shay collected opinions from Feyburg like cold dusty slugs from the floor of the shop, none of them the same, and never amounting to much. Finally, she asked Nana Dantwit for a red and orange quilt. The short bed was built from birch boughs. They named the child Zephyr, since she blew in from nowhere. Shay knew her from the sound she made banging the loose shutters on the cabin and by the way the forging fire flared up without being stoked or urged by bellows.

An old woman with worms moving around the earth of her brain, Shay shook her head to settle the dirt. Remembering she sent Zephyr to Nana's for duck eggs and a fist of butter, if they could spare it, she went to the edge of the clearing to watch for the girl.

That morning, the weather turned blue and the wind grew claws. Zephyr had buckled her new shoes, and made up a song. How did the lines turn?

Over the bridge. Down the lane.

You've been there before. You go there again. Fires may burn. Water may rain.

Little girl lost. Come this way.

As Zephyr was not wont to such child-like games, the rhyme prodded the blacksmith in the deeper clay of her brain, spoon-digging at the mystery of whence the child came, why no one missed her. Deeper than clay, lodged somewhere in bedrock, with the rubies and garnets, slept the more terrible question: why did Zephyr adore fire?

Not a month after Zephyr appeared, she snuck into the blacksmith, one barefoot on the bellows, the other clutching an unworked iron rod whose tip, when she withdrew it, glowed star-like white. While Shay looked on from the shadows, the little girl raised the iron to her cheek and held it there for an interminable second. Shay cried out; Zephyr's iron thudded to the dirt and she stared as though she'd been caught desecrating an altar. In silence, they held each other. Shay glistened her unfamiliar daughter's cheek with red bark salve and rocked her into a tearless sleep.

Shay approached the foot-bridge. Zephyr should have returned, the basket banging against her knees without breaking any eggs. A midday bird dove at her bright cap. Had a mockingbird built a nest this close to the house? And in the month of bare trees? Shay often felt alarmed by creatures and sounds, which she ascribed to aging. Worried, Shay wrapped herself in a shawl and decided to meet Zephyr midway. Perhaps she could collect a few pecans from a neighboring orchard.

From the bridge, she spied Zephyr facing the stream, her back to her mother. Shay came up behind her, looking for a mockingbird or beaver, whatever had drawn her daughter's attention. A white dress swirled, caught in an eddy between large boulders.

Once Zephyr sensed someone beside her, she threw her arms up in alarm. "Oh, Mother, come quickly!"

She never had called the woman mother. Only then did Shay notice that the white swirl was not a dress nor a doll but an impossibly small infant. She let the shawl slide from her shoulders, stooped to remove her shoes. The icy water soaking her skirts harbored the power to purify, and yet its wet wailing would not drown out the voice, the small, small song.

Cats
Winston Plowes

I have shouldered stiff legs,
bin lined dead weights.

Crossing over the old bridge
to the waste ground.

I have dug out boulder stones
Pouring soil on blood-face
Beetle kissed
Tulip bottle graves.

15 Floors
Beth Bowser

John scraped himself off the floor, wincing as his head protested the sudden movement. He glanced up at the flight of stairs he had fallen from. Ten flights. Some would call him lucky. He slowly made his way back to his apartment, glancing at the time on his noisy phone packed full of missed calls, messages and voicemails.

"Where were you! I demand to know right now!" was what greeted him on passing the hallway to apartment threshold. His wife Felicity was full of loving words to him always. That was one of her favorites, but she also liked "Why do you hate me?", "You never do anything for me!" and "I hate you!". He considering going back out to the stairs but realized he had to shower for work.

"The hallway."

"I mean, last night, you idiot! Not immediately before now!" he noticed some spittle around her lips. She was always as ready as a rabid dog to fight.

"The hallway."

"You're telling me you spent the whole night in our apartment hallway? Why? Found a hooker and she refused to go to a room with you? You are so disgusting! I never should have married you. My mother was right!" Throughout the tirade, John just continued further into the apartment to the bathroom, bypassing his perfect wife.

"Oh my god!! What happened to you?" She caught up to him and ran her fingers lightly over the back of his head.

"I just need to take a shower. Can't be late for work."

"But what happened? You poor thing! The back of your head... it's so purple and raw and red. Stay right there, I will get the first-aid kit!" As she went to leave, he grabbed her wrist.

"Thanks dearest, but I'll be fine. No need to put yourself out on account of me." Best bipolar nurse in the world.

She was speechless almost until he reached the bathroom. "What?! Are you trying to say that you would rather be in pain than allow me to treat your injury? And you never answered! Where were you? Did you fall somewhere?"

He turned around to face her "The hallway." and took the last step backwards into the bathroom before shutting the door.

He had to wash gingerly. Both to ensure that all signs of his fall were gone, no visible blood or torn skin tags, but also scrub very delicately as the spot was incredibly sore. When he did accidentally use too much force, the area dented inwards in a sickening fashion. The sensation almost made him lose consciousness again, but his battered and bruised body never succumbed easily. To anything. Feeling emboldened, he varied his presses, experimenting on what hurt the most, which spot increased his dizziness, what section could be pushed in the furthest. Once he had a map of the dented area complete to his satisfaction, he finished the shower, dressed and headed to the office, narrowly avoiding Felicity on his way out.

Tim and Andrew both greeted him and warned him that their boss Prateek was in a foul mood today and livid over John's being unreachable yesterday evening. Andrew appeared to take delight in knowing that he was not the scapegoat for once and gleefully told him that good news. Tim appeared worried about him and asked where he had been.

"The hallway".

He wasted no time and presented himself at Prateek's office. "Prateek? Sorry about yesterday but I wasn't able to call you and let you know I wouldn't be available."

"John, John, John, John. Just the man I wanted to see. Do you know how much shit we are in? The express change order I had given you two days STILL is not complete and we have some very angry clients!"

"I am sorry that I wasn't able to finish the C/O but I was otherwise engaged with my emergency appointment between the back of my skull and the floor." Honestly, he wanted to say that he was tired. That this monotony of working forever with nothing ever changing, no matter what was attempted. That he had been here enough to know he was just a rat in this dead-end maze of which no cheese existed no matter how much you strove? But he wasn't stupid. He loathed the position, the boss, the work but there was worse he supposed.

"Speak plainly for once in your life John or you're out! I can't seem to rely on you anymore."

"Prateek, to speak plainly, as best I can figure, when I left for work yesterday morning, I fell on the stairs leading down and landed ten flights of stairs further down on my head. I woke up this morning, made my way back up, showered and here I am." He held his hands and arms out in a "Ta-dah" fashion, showcasing the purple and red bruise around his head - clearly visible though his hair

"Oh my" Prateek sighed heavily. "I don't want to do this, but I feel I have no choice. You used to be one of my best workers, always able to complete high quality quick turnarounds but in the past couple months, you seem to be missing work more and more frequently, citing strange accidents. Consider this your last warning as a boss and as a friend. Fix whatever is going on with you. Do whatever treatments are necessary. Just fix it. Please." He waved irritated at the door that the meeting was over. John took no extra prompting. He knew this conversation, this day, and others like it all too well. He remembered it what, hundred times? A thousand?

He resolved to try for fifteen floors tonight. He would get out of this unchanging purgatory, he needed to.

The Rats
Vicente Muñoz

It was through the old streets of Jerusalem, at night, with trembling torches in one hand, the other at the ready to draw for the threat of Saladin was near.

The night stood quiet, too quiet, the wind from time to time hit the patrol tenderly but every time it felt as if a knife was crossing through their skin, that they had been betrayed by their senses and their death had finally arrived, unnoticed.

None of this had happened so far, the weeks at night quiet but tense and even more during the day with everyone waiting for the dreaded strike, the patrols doubled and tripled, men pushed to the brink by the horror of a full scale attack, how would they fare, how long could they survive, how horrible would be their death, some had come to bet on the situation, the money had been hidden in a reservoir, at the bottom inside a small iron box, for the survivors to live off from it as an insurance, others would drink it all away and hope for the best, or the worst.

Throughout the dead streets they heard their own footsteps, always wary of the direction the sound came from it never ceased to stress them, their armor crunching and ripping, leather and metal in clash, the torches cracking slowly and if they stood quiet long enough not only could they hear their breathing, their heartbeat throbbed hard on their ears, almost on their necks, fast.

It wasn't long for them to find an oddity in the streets, a man lay dead, at first they stood in shock at the visage, then rapidly attended the body to find the culprit, their failure to rapidly grasp what was happening led them to their doom.

Rats, rushing out of the shadows in the hundreds, silently awaiting for their next pray, screams of panic and warning were followed by those of pain and horror, the torches did little to put them out of harms way, swords ineffective with such small targets even in the quantities present they seemed well aware of their intentions and evaded easily, their armors useless as the rodents flew towards their face and any openings between legs, arms or chest, no flesh left to tear, no bones left to gnaw, the metal and leather turn to pieces or taken away by the wave, the torches only a few splinters now, nothing remained save for the infusion of terror that the surrounding inhabitants had to live with every night, pray the next victims were not them.

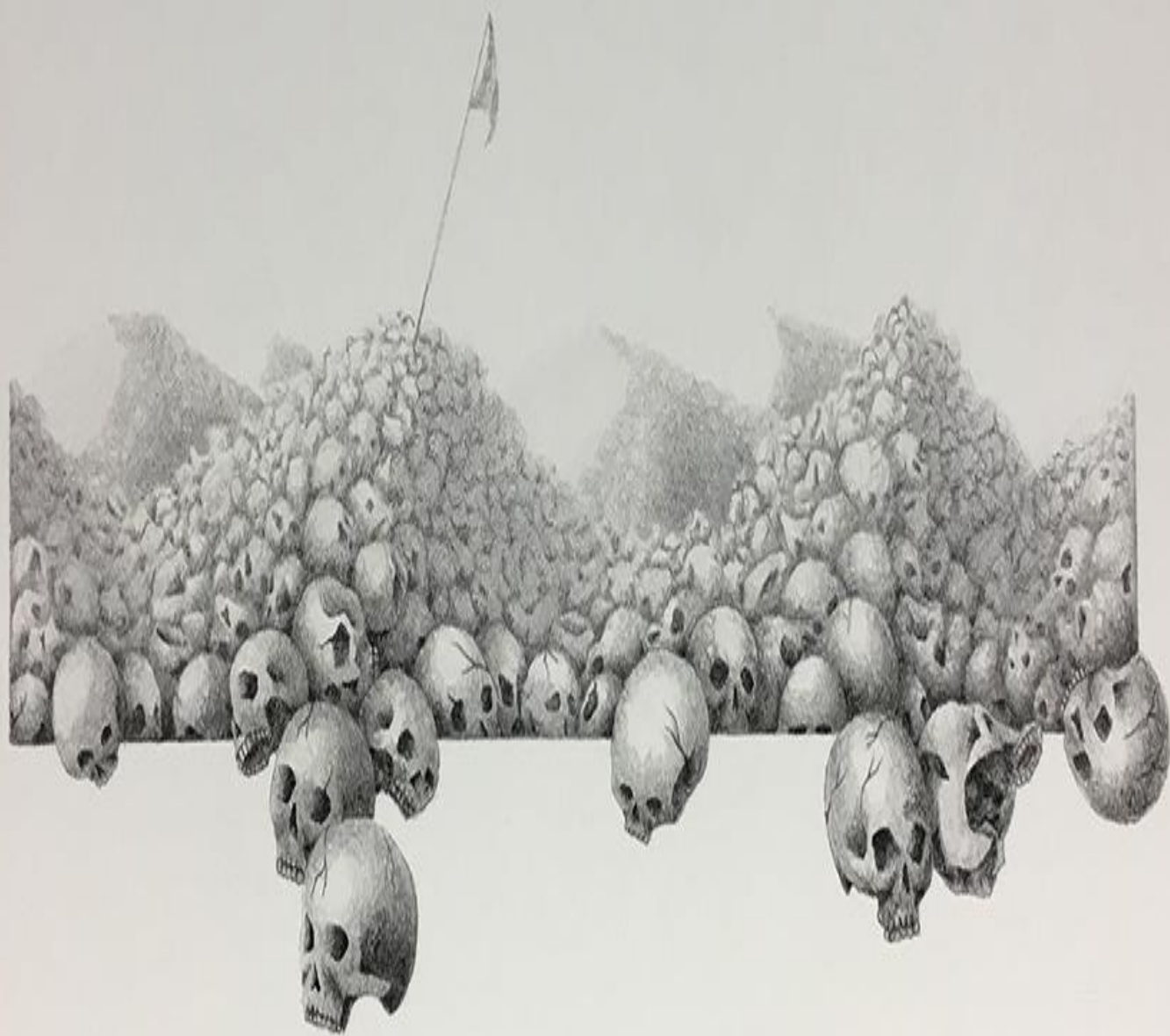
Ghostwriters
Kate Bernadette Benedict

The parlor is empty now; do not bewail it.
However intellectual, the doings here had a sinister aspect— secret handshakes, false elections,
everyone milling and whispering
with their minds attending the supreme Author,
whether he was present bodily or not.
They were the real authors but dared not take credit.
So many volumes, and published so beautifully,
with marbled endpapers and gilded stock.

Nothing on those shelves now but a filthy foil ashtray or two. I admit I nearly joined them.
The hazing would not be intolerable, they said.
Acts of confession, mostly,

no cruelty, kink, or cum left out.
I quailed at the idea of that
but I wanted to add my name to their anonymity. Too late.
A pollution took hold here—
the less said, the better.

The less we disturb the place, the better. It's already been looted, after all, except for the old registry.
Isn't that your name there, in redletter?



Contributors

Fiction & Poetry

Alicia Alcantara-Narrea, "The Me Without Perception"

Alicia Alcantara-Narrea is an undergraduate creative writing major at the University of Houston and indie author of the short story "The Gas Station Attendant." She is an assistant prose editor for the UH Literary Journal Glass Mountain with a poem forthcoming in The Merrimack Review.

Beth Bowser, "15 Floors"

Beth Bowser has been an avid reader with a passion for creative writing since she was a young girl growing up in Michigan. Flitting about to various US states, finding her husband, and overcoming medical and other challenges has honed Beth's craft and brought out a unique worldview. Beth's writings are occasionally interrupted when she must praise her cat for bringing "murder presents," but she continues to craft new worlds, strange characters, and insightful situations for her readers. You may find Beth in the odd corners of your imagination, if you are lucky.

Casey Reinhardt, "cow."

Casey Reinhardt is a writer from Buffalo, NY where she dreams up madness, most of which makes its way into a story or poem. Some will remain in the dream-realm for all eternity. Work can be found in Apparition Lit and upcoming TL;DR Press Women's Anthology. Find her on twitter @yoscully.

Catherine Keller, "Ode to Brockport," "Reminiscence"

Born and bred in Buffalo, Catherine Keller published her first poetry chapbook, *Sonder*, in June 2018, which is available on Amazon. She has also had poetry published in eight literary magazines including Wilderness House Literary Review, Tipton Poetry Journal, The Stray Branch, and Hooligan Magazine and editorials for the NeXt section in the Buffalo News. She has been writing creatively for as long as she can remember and is also in the midst of writing ten other stories that will be novels and short story collections (eventually). When she's not writing, she spends her time chasing sunsets, waterfalls and free food, which you can check out on her Instagram @catiekeller.

Chris Bullard, "The Hardy Boys and The Mystery of the Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder"

Chris Bullard is a native of Jacksonville, FL. He lives in Philadelphia, PA. He received his B.A. in English from the University of Pennsylvania and his M.F.A. from Wilkes University. He has published two full length books and four chapbooks of poetry. Big Table Press published *Fear*, a collection of his science fiction and horror short stories, in 2017.

Edward Varga, "The Caterpillar Curse"

Edward Varga is a fiction writer of a wide variety of genres from picture book texts to screenplays. Find him on Twitter @edwardvarga.

Erica Wahlgren, "Escape," "Shattered Glass"

Erica Wahlgren is a Literature and Writing Studies M.A. student at CSUSM researching constructed spaces in both literature and video games and is teaching a composition course this fall. Her poetry has also appeared in the 2018 edition of Bravura.

Julian/Sara Mithra, “Apiary Musk,” “Splintering,” “Zephyr and the Smith”

Julian née Sara Mithra hovers between genre and gender, border mongering and mongreling. Their first book, *If the Color is Fugitive* (Nomadic Press, 2018) follows vagrants around the collapsing frontier during a queer elsewhen. At local festivals, they exhibit handmade chapbooks and cut-up zines. They received the Prospero Prize from Fathom Books in 2017. For a Master’s in Folklore Studies at UC Berkeley, Sara dressed up as a 19th century anthropologist and spoke through a copper pipe. They eke out a living in Oakland by encouraging young people to write.

Kate Bernadette Benedict, “Ghostwriters”**SaraEve, “Talking to My Mother About Suicide and #MeToo, 2018,” “Ode to the Other Woman”**

SaraEve is a performance poet and epilepsy advocate from northeast New Jersey. A 2015 Best of the Net nominee, she has performed for both local and national events, including the Epilepsy Foundation of Greater Los Angeles 2015 Care and Cure Benefit to End Epilepsy in Children and as a reader for Great Weather for MEDIA at the 2016 NYC Poetry Festival on Governors Island. She is the author of *You Must Be This Tall to Ride* (Swimming With Elephants Publishing) and *View from the Top of the Ferris Wheel* (Clare Songbirds Publishing House). She loves Instagram: @SaraEve41.

Vicente Muñoz, “The Rats”

Vicente Muñoz decided to study a Bachelors in History at UABC in Tijuana but has always worked in IT, even though he has always had mixed feelings and results in the field. Usually writes as a hobby and plans to publish something, someday. Once went up on a stage to cover for a missing vocalist and was told it sounded like someone reading violent poetry.

Winston Plowes, “Cats,” “Gallery Attendant”

Winston Plowes is a word artist from Mytholmroyd, Calderdale interested in surrealism, all species of art, the magic of chance operations and the personalities of cheese. His life is a mission to discover how and why the currency of words makes us love, hide, laugh, cry or dance. He teaches pupils from yr1 to degree level and regularly performs at and organizes festivals and events. He has adopted over twenty typewriters that follow him round the country. Recent publications include *Telephones, Love Hearts & Jellyfish* (Electric Press 2016) and *Tales from the Tachograph* with Gaia Holmes (Calder Valley Poetry 2017).

Artwork**Gergely Bukovinszki, “Cradle to Grave,” “Trauma to be passed on”**

Gergely is a visual artist living and working in the UK. He paints about life as he sees it, raw and painful, with a bit of humor injected at times. Gergely aims to tell stories that reflect his views about modern society, the challenges we must face living as human beings, and express those in the form of figurative art.

Jeronimo Batista Rosa Chaveiro, “Let’s Dance”

Jeronimo’s work is an examination of the different faces of human beings. He loves altering them as a

way of questioning attitudes; destroying the paper to rebuild, decontextualize, then reconstruct.
Jeronimo can be found on social media as @NomadeCollage.

Yasuaki Okamoto, "Founding of Nation"

